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‘If the Boys Are to be Hanged’

The suggestion that Gandhi wished to dissociate himself from ‘the revolutionary business’ in a way that it made ‘a great difference’ to the viceroy has been much overlooked by those who say that Gandhi spared no effort. The fact that the viceroy realized that the Mahatma ‘would not break [the accord] on that question’ is the most compelling indication of Gandhi not doing enough to save Bhagat Singh. This was at precisely the moment when he could have done so. Gandhi well knew that the viceroy himself did not wish the accord to break. So why did he not dig his heels in? Was he complicit in the viceroy’s decision? If so, that is a grave allegation to make. Nevertheless, the enormity of the Mahatma’s act of omission is all the more glaring considering, as Bose recalls, that by the time the Congress was to meet at Karachi on 26 March 1931, ‘the general expectation was that the execution would be cancelled.’ This is why ‘[i]t was therefore a most painful and unexpected surprise when on March 24, while we were on our way to Karachi from Calcutta, the news was received that Sardar Bhagat Singh and his comrades had been hanged the night before’.[1] Clearly horrified, he recounts how ‘[i]t is impossible to understand the poignant grief which stirred the country from one end to the other’. This is because by now, ‘[s]omehow or other, Bhagat Singh had become the symbol of the new awakening among the youths’ so that ‘[w]hen the Mahatma alighted near Karachi, there was a hostile demonstration, and several young men received him with black flowers and black garments. The feeling among a considerable section of the youths was that the Mahatma had betrayed the cause of Bhagat Singh and his comrades’.[2] Did the Mahatma then really betray the cause of Bhagat Singh? Did his pusillanimous approach to saving